GRACE COMMUNITY
CHURCH

Faith: 101 Bible Study

METHODISM: 101

SESSION 1: HISTORY & FOUNDATIONS

Where did we come from?

Wednesday, October 21, 2026

7:00 PM ET · Zoom & Facebook Live

Rev. Dr. Arian B. Harris

OPENING PRAYER

> Gracious God, you loved us before we knew your name. Open our minds to learn where we come from, and open our hearts to the same fire that warmed the people before us. **In Jesus' name, Amen.**

QUESTION A

OPENING · TALK ABOUT IT

What’s one thing you were taught about the church you grew up in — or one thing you’ve always wondered about Methodists?

Type it in the chat or unmute.

PART 1

A MOVEMENT, NOT A NEW CHURCH

Oxford · London · Bristol · Baltimore

1729 · OXFORD

THE “HOLY CLUB”

- Charles Wesley starts a small group of students at Oxford; his brother John soon leads it.
- Prayer, Scripture, Communion, fasting, visiting prisoners, serving the poor — on a strict schedule.
- Mocked as “Methodists” for their method. They kept the name.
- **A renewal movement inside the Church of England**, not a new church.

B QUESTION B

PART 1 · TALK ABOUT IT

Wesley’s friends were mocked for being so “methodical.” If someone watched your week, what spiritual habits would they notice?

> *“Train yourself to be godly.”* **1 Timothy 4:7 (NIV)**

MAY 24, 1738 · LONDON

ALDERSGATE

> *“I felt my heart strangely warmed. I felt I did trust in Christ, Christ alone, for salvation; and an assurance was given me that he had taken away my sins.”*
>
> **John Wesley’s journal**

C QUESTION C

PART 1 · TALK ABOUT IT

Have you had an “Aldersgate moment,” when your heart was “strangely warmed”? Or has your faith warmed slowly over time?

> *“Were not our hearts burning within us while he talked with us on the road and opened the Scriptures to us?”* **Luke 24:32 (NIV)**

1739 · BRISTOL

FIELD PREACHING & SOCIAL HOLINESS

- Many pulpits close to Wesley. George Whitefield urges him to preach outdoors.
- Coal miners and working families hear the gospel where they are.

> *“The gospel of Christ knows of no religion, but social; no holiness, but social holiness.”*
>
> **John Wesley, 1739 · faith grows together, then reaches out**

QUESTION D

PART 1 · TALK ABOUT IT

Wesley said there is “no holiness but social holiness.” Who helps you grow in faith — and whom are you helping grow?

> *“Let us consider how we may spur one another on toward love and good deeds.”* **Hebrews 10:24 (NIV)**

1784 · BALTIMORE

METHODISM COMES TO AMERICA

- The “Christmas Conference” organizes the **Methodist Episcopal Church**.
- Bishop Francis Asbury travels the country on horseback.
- Black Methodists are there from the start — including **Harry Hosier**, a gifted preacher who rode with Asbury.

PART 2

FOUR FAMILIES, ONE STORY

Race, freedom and the Methodist family tree

GRACE COMMUNITY CHURCH

METHODISM IN TEN DATES



1729 The “Holy Club” meets at Oxford

1738 Aldersgate: Wesley’s heart “strangely warmed”

1739 Field preaching begins

1784 Methodist Episcopal Church founded in Baltimore

1816 AME Church founded in Philadelphia

1821 AME Zion Church organized in New York

1844 Methodism splits North and South over slavery

1870 CME Church organized in Jackson, Tennessee

1939 Segregated “Central Jurisdiction” created

1968 United Methodist Church formed; Central Jurisdiction ends

Racism — segregated seating, denied ordination and compromise with slavery — split the Methodist family. In 1844 the Methodist Episcopal Church itself divided North and South over slavery.

1816 · PHILADELPHIA

AFRICAN METHODIST EPISCOPAL (AME)

- At St. George’s Church, Black worshipers are pulled up off their knees while praying. They walk out together.
- Richard Allen founds Bethel (1794); Absalom Jones founds St. Thomas African Episcopal Church.
- Bethel wins control of its own building in court in 1816. That April, the **AME Church** is born — the first independent Black denomination. Allen is its first bishop.

RIGHT AROUND THE CORNER

MOTHER BETHEL STILL STANDS

419 South 6th Street, Philadelphia — a short walk from where Grace worships. Richard Allen bought the land in 1791.

WALK THE HISTORY

Richard Allen is buried at Mother Bethel. Its museum tells the story of the walkout and the founding of the AME Church.

E QUESTION E

PART 2 · TALK ABOUT IT

Richard Allen and Absalom Jones were pulled up off their knees while praying. What does that moment say about how the church has treated people — and how should it treat them?

> *“There is neither Jew nor Gentile, neither slave nor free… for you are all one in Christ Jesus.”* **Galatians 3:28 (NIV)**

1821 · NEW YORK

AME ZION · “THE FREEDOM CHURCH”

- Led by James Varick, Black members of John Street Church leave segregated Communion and denial of ordination behind.
- Worship separately from 1796; Zion chapel 1800; denomination organized 1821.
- Harriet Tubman, Frederick Douglass and Sojourner Truth were connected to it.
- Early to ordain women: Julia Foote (deacon, 1894) and Mary J. Small (elder, 1898).

1870 · JACKSON, TENNESSEE · OUR FAMILY

CHRISTIAN METHODIST EPISCOPAL (CME)

- Before the Civil War, more than 200,000 Black people belonged to the Methodist Episcopal Church, South.
- After emancipation, those who stayed asked for a church governed by themselves.
- December 1870: organized as the **Colored** Methodist Episcopal Church. First bishops: William H. Miles and Richard H. Vanderhorst.
- “Colored” became **“Christian”** in 1956. Colleges: Lane, Miles, Paine, Texas.

1968 · DALLAS

THE UNITED METHODIST CHURCH

- 1939: northern and southern Methodists reunite — and put every Black congregation in a separate, segregated **Central Jurisdiction**.
- 1968: merger with the Evangelical United Brethren forms the UMC and ends the Central Jurisdiction.
- 2019–2023: thousands of congregations leave; many join the new Global Methodist Church.

QUESTION F

PART 2 · TALK ABOUT IT

Allen walked out and built something new. Others stayed and worked for change from inside. When is leaving the right response, and when is staying?

QUESTION G

PART 2 · TALK ABOUT IT

Grace is part of the CME Church, founded by formerly enslaved people who wanted to govern their own church. What does it mean to you to belong to this story?

> *“You also, like living stones, are being built into a spiritual house.”* **1 Peter 2:5 (NIV)**

PART 3

WHAT METHODISTS BELIEVE

Grace · rules · a way of thinking

THREE KINDS OF GRACE

PREVENIENT

Grace that goes before. God's love reaches us before we know God, drawing us to respond.

"We love because he first loved us."

1 John 4:19

JUSTIFYING

Grace that pardons. Forgiveness and a restored relationship with God, received by faith — a gift.

"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith."

Ephesians 2:8

SANCTIFYING

Grace that transforms. The Holy Spirit growing us toward perfect love of God and neighbor.

"If anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come."

2 Corinthians 5:17

Scripture: NIV

WESLEY'S PICTURE

THE PORCH, THE DOOR, THE HOUSE

THE PORCH

Repentance. God's grace meets us outside and turns us toward home.

THE DOOR

Faith. We walk in, forgiven and welcomed.

THE HOUSE

Holiness. A whole life of growing in love, room by room.

QUESTION H

PART 3 · TALK ABOUT IT

Which do you most need right now: grace that finds you (prevenient), grace that forgives you (justifying), or grace that grows you (sanctifying)?

THE GENERAL RULES · 1743

THREE SIMPLE RULES

1 · DO NO HARM

“Hate what is evil; cling to what is good.”

Romans 12:9

2 · DO GOOD

“Let us do good to all people.”

Galatians 6:10

“Act justly… love mercy… walk humbly with your God.”

Micah 6:8

3 · STAY IN LOVE WITH GOD

“If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit.”

John 15:5

Wesley’s wording: “attending upon all the ordinances of God” — prayer, Scripture, Communion, worship, fasting. “Stay in love with God” is Bishop Rueben Job’s summary.

QUESTION 1

PART 3 · TALK ABOUT IT

Which of the three simple rules — do no harm, do good, stay in love with God — is hardest for you right now? What would practicing it look like this week?

> *“He has shown you, O mortal, what is good.”* **Micah 6:8 (NIV)**

THE WESLEYAN QUADRILATERAL

Four sources for thinking through hard questions. **Scripture is the foundation.**

1 · SCRIPTURE

Primary authority.

2 Timothy 3:16–17

2 · TRADITION

The church's wisdom through history.

2 Thessalonians 2:15

3 · REASON

"Come now, and let us reason together."

Isaiah 1:18 (KJV)

4 · EXPERIENCE

The Spirit's witness in our lives.

Romans 8:16

Named by 20th-century scholar Albert Outler to describe Wesley's method.

QUESTION J

PART 3 · TALK ABOUT IT

Try the Quadrilateral: should I forgive someone who hasn't apologized? What do Scripture, tradition, reason and experience each add?

> *"Lord, how many times shall I forgive…? Up to seven times? Jesus answered, 'I tell you, not seven times, but seventy-seven times.'"* **Matthew 18:21–22 (NIV)**

SCRIPTURE	TRADITION	REASON	EXPERIENCE
What does the Bible say?	What has the church taught?	What makes sense here?	What have you lived?

TONIGHT IN ONE SLIDE

- Methodism began as a **renewal movement** of disciplined, heart-warmed faith.
- When racism pushed Black Methodists out, they built the **AME, AME Zion and CME** churches. Grace is CME.
- Grace goes before us, pardons us and transforms us.
- Do no harm. Do good. Stay in love with God.
- Scripture first, with tradition, reason and experience.

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE

TRY ALL THREE RULES

DO NO HARM

One habit, word or reaction to give up for seven days.

DO GOOD

One person to help, by name, before next Wednesday.

STAY IN LOVE WITH GOD

One daily practice: 10 minutes of prayer, or a psalm a day.

Write them on your handout and bring your story next week.

CLOSING PRAYER

God of Aldersgate and Mother Bethel, of Jackson, Tennessee and South Philadelphia: thank you for the people who carried this faith to us, some of them at great cost. Warm our hearts again. Teach us to do no harm, to do good, and to stay in love with you. **Amen.**

NEXT WEDNESDAY

Methodism: 101 · Session 2

7:00 PM ET on Zoom

ID 880 2297 9559 · Passcode 19061906

Handout: gracecommunityphilly.org

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